

What the Landers hearing put on the record

After months of closure discussion, MUSD said the detailed analysis is still being developed. The hearing sharpened the issue from “*Is Landers small?*” to “*Is the case for closing it complete?*”

THE HEADLINE

“The numbers that you're looking at right now are... I would say are **ballpark.**”

DISTRICT RESPONSE

WHAT THE DISTRICT ARGUED

- **Enrollment pressure is real.** At the hearing, MUSD said district enrollment was about 7,400 in 1986 with seven elementary schools; about 9,700 in 2006 with 11 schools; and about 7,300 in 2026 while still operating 11.
- **Landers is much smaller than it once was.** The presentation cited 223 students in 2005, 143 in 2018 and 107 in 2026.
- **Scale can affect programs and staffing.** District staff said roughly 400-450 students is an “optimal” high-desert elementary size and pointed to combination classes and specialist staffing.

WHAT THE HEARING EXPOSED

- **The complete net number is still missing.** The published Landers figures - \$368,512, \$629,378 and \$908,176 - are personnel-savings tiers, not a single line-item net model.
- **Transportation grows.** MUSD's own scenario moves combined Landers/Yucca Mesa routes from 6 to 9.
- **More receiving-site work remains.** A district response said more analysis is needed and funds would have to be invested before the option could proceed.
- **The Board has asked for deeper analysis.** District staff said that information is expected at the October Board meeting; Oct. 13 was referenced in the exchange.

87.1%

economically disadvantaged
Landers profile

18

students identified as homeless
Landers profile

15.1%

students with disabilities
Landers profile

Chronic absenteeism in the multi-year profile improved from 34.5% to 29.7% to 25.9%. The community's argument was not that Landers has no challenges, but that a high-need rural school showing improvement should not be closed on incomplete math.

IRREVERSIBLE

“Closing a school is forever.”
Community speaker

UNFINISHED

“There's still analysis to be done...”
District response

THE PUBLIC FRAME

“We are the ones who remain here.”
Community comment

What still needs an answer

The next phase should test the proposal where it is weakest: the full ledger, the receiving school, and the record of alternatives.

EIGHT QUESTIONS BEFORE ANY VOTE

- 1 What is the recurring net savings?** Show personnel savings minus transportation, receiving-site staffing, facility work, transition costs and any enrollment loss.
- 2 What must be spent at Yucca Mesa first?** Identify rooms, staffing, special education, traffic, food service, supervision and other changes.
- 3 What does each of the three personnel tiers actually mean?** Which jobs disappear from district payroll and which transfer elsewhere?
- 4 What transportation model supports consolidation?** Route cost, staffing, fleet capacity, run times and implementation date.
- 5 What happens if families leave MUSD?** Publish attrition scenarios and the break-even point.
- 6 Which Enrollment Committee alternatives were implemented?** Give a status, date, target and result for each recommendation.
- 7 Where is the equity-impact analysis?** Landers serves a high-need population and transportation is a central rural barrier.
- 8 What central-office reductions are on the same decision table?** The district said a position-control review is underway; publish the options and dollar totals.

THE COMMITTEE QUESTION

At the hearing, a response about recommendations prompted an immediate correction from the room:

“That was School Leaders though. She wants to know the 7-11 Committee's recommendations.”

The final committee report said closures should be a last resort and recommended MUSD refrain from closing schools while viable enrollment, retention and efficiency strategies are implemented and evaluated.

NEXT DIRECTION: YUCCA MESA

The Sept. 22 hearing should not repeat “don't close Landers.” It should ask the receiving-school question:

What exactly is Yucca Mesa being asked to absorb - and what will it cost?

- Capacity and class-size plan
- Special education and intervention staffing
- Traffic, buses and pickup/drop-off
- Facility work and one-time investment
- Programs promised through consolidation
- Timeline and transition plan

“Closing a school is forever.”

COMMUNITY SPEAKER

Source note. Primary sources: Sept. 10 Landers hearing working transcript; MUSD Enrollment/7-11 Committee Final Report; MUSD Enrollment Committee Review / transportation scenario; MUSD personnel-savings table; Landers multi-year SPSSA profile.